

BILL SHAPES

Over millions of years, birds have evolved many different bill shapes. Here are five of them, each designed to help the bird eat or catch its prey.



Seed-eater
Birds such as crossbills have strong bills for eating seeds. The crossbill can extract seeds from pine cones with its overlapping bill.



Water-sifter
Flamingos have long, wide bills that they sweep from side to side in shallow waters, sifting out animals to eat.



Nectar-gatherer
The pointed bills are designed for precision. Sunbirds' bills also curve downward, which is ideal for extracting flower nectar.

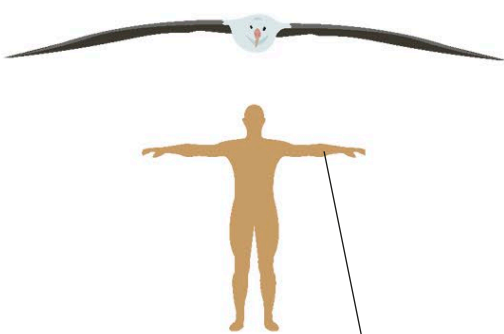


Mud probe
Birds with long, sensitive bills can explore soft mud in search of prey. The snipe looks for snails and small crustaceans.



Butchery tool
This hooked bill, as seen on a golden eagle, is perfect for stripping meat from the bones of fish, birds, or mammals.

THE **LARGEST FLYING BIRD** IS THE **WANDERING ALBATROSS**, WITH A WINGSPAN OF **12 FT** (3.6 M).



The average female arm span is about 5.2 ft (1.6 m).

BIGGEST BIRD AND EGGS



THE **OSTRICH**, A **FLIGHTLESS BIRD** FROM **SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA**, IS THE **WORLD'S TALLEST BIRD**.

IT ALSO BEARS THE **LARGEST EGGS**, UP TO **6 IN** (15 CM) LONG—NEARLY THREE TIMES LONGER THAN A HEN'S EGG.

SMALLEST BIRD

THE **BEE HUMMINGBIRD** IS JUST **2.4 IN** (6 CM) LONG. THIS TINY BIRD IS NATIVE TO **CUBA**.



FASTEST BIRD

Found throughout the world, peregrine falcons are formidable hunters. They swoop in on prey, such as other birds and bats, at a record-breaking speed.

SWOOPING SPEED = 200 MPH (320 KPH)



RÜPPELL'S VULTURE

35,000 FT (10,670 M)

HIGHEST-FLYING BIRD

RÜPPELL'S VULTURE CAN REACH AN ALTITUDE OF **37,000 FT** (11,280 M), HIGHER THAN THE CRUISING ALTITUDE OF AN AIRPLANE.



BIGGEST NEST

SOCIABLE WEAVERS MAKE AND MAINTAIN NESTS THAT CAN HOUSE UP TO **500** BIRDS.



SMART BIRD

Found in the remote Pacific islands after which it is named, the New Caledonian crow can manipulate and use twigs to dig out prey, such as grubs, from trees. These intelligent forest-dwelling birds are the first to be observed making and using tools in this way.

